militarily, the US would have to intervene since “the whole Western power position in Asia may be at stake.”[227]

With Chinese condemnations continuing, along with accusations that India could not have taken action without US “consent and support,”[228] Johnson took a more active interest, concerned that “the stakes were far bigger than Kashmir.” He stressed to B. K. Nehru the need to find a solution, ideally through the UN.[229] As China’s threats persisted,[230] with Vietnam on his mind, Johnson expressed his major preoccupation vis-à-vis the crisis in his question to McNamara: “What about the Chinese?”[231]

At a closed session on the conflict, Rusk told the Senate Foreign Relations Committee that the “first big question is China” and whether it would get involved militarily. At that stage the administration did not know, but “we have to assume they are certainly thinking very hard about it.” When asked what the administration would do if China intervened, Rusk said that was “an enormous question, one of the greatest importance.… Much will depend upon where and in what way and what else is happening.”[232]

Meanwhile, the Defense Department was evaluating its operational plans, which included strengthening Indian air defenses, and possible US air force intervention in case China intervened; it was also planning to resume military aid to India for use against China.[233] On September 15, the US used the Warsaw channel to warn China that any intervention would be ill advised; its threats “if pursued, could create a most dangerous situation, which it would be difficult to confine to the areas or parties initially affected.” Rusk publicly reiterated the warning.[234]

A mid-September intelligence estimate did not think that China would do more than provide political and token military support to Pakistan or instigate smaller skirmishes unless Pakistan’s defeat became imminent.[235] As Pakistan’s situation deteriorated, however, on September 16 another Chinese ultimatum to India—this time with a deadline after which there would be “serious consequences”—ratcheted up concern about potential Chinese military intervention.[236]

Washington took a tough line with Pakistan when it tried to use the Chinese threats to its advantage. Ayub demanded a US statement of support for Pakistan or that the US condition any support to India against China on a Kashmir settlement. As he had done with Kennedy, Ayub suggested that if